

was inevitable that data was frequently inflated. Worse was the fact that hamlets under total communist control were not included in the system.

Limited success

The Tet Offensive of early 1968 proved a major setback for CORDS. The evacuation of rural areas, a massive flow of refugees to coastal and urban areas, and the diversion of personnel and funding to the counterattacks impacted the CORDS program. Once the NVA offensive was thwarted, the program regained its momentum.

By 1969, CORDS had established military-civilian advisory teams in more than 250 districts and had some 7,000 personnel involved in pacification. It also utilized two types of local militia—Regional Forces (RF) and Popular Forces (PF), known collectively as Ruff-Puffs to their American advisers—who grew into an effective fighting force. Through them, CORDS could provide some security for villages vulnerable to Viet Cong attacks.

However, CORDS mostly failed when it came to convincing Viet Cong troops and other communist sympathizers to come to the side of the US and South Vietnamese. Appointed as the US Ambassador to Turkey in 1968, Komer turned over control of CORDS to his deputy: intelligence expert William Colby, who had once served as CIA Chief of Station in Saigon and later became director of the CIA.



Playtime

Sometimes hearts and minds were won with small, spur-of-the-moment actions, like this American GI interacting with a Vietnamese child as she uses the antibomb sandbags in front of her home as a playground.